

TABLE 7.5 (CONT'D) PROPORTION OF CURRENTLY MARRIED AND NEVER MARRIED FEMALES IN THE FOUR AGRO ECOLOGICAL ZONES - 1963 AND 1971.

Proportion & Year	Age Group						
	15 - 19	20 - 24	25 - 29	30 - 34	35 - 39	40 - 44	45 - 49
<u>Zone 3.</u>							
Proportion Currently married							
1963	29.4	70.8	87.7	92.4	90.9	85.7	79.5
1971	20.1	59.3	81.7	89.6	90.5	86.7	82.4
% Change	-31.6	-16.2	+ 5.9	- 3.0	- 0.4	+ 1.5	+ 5.9
Never married							
1963	70.2	28.2	10.4	3.8	2.2	2.0	1.9
1971	79.5	39.5	15.9	6.7	3.2	2.5	2.3
% Change	+13.2	+40.1	+72.1	+76.3	+45.5	+25.0	+21.1
<u>Zone 4.</u>							
Currently married							
1963	14.8	62.3	84.8	91.1	90.5	86.4	81.8
1971	8.6	45.9	76.1	87.2	89.7	87.2	83.7
% Change	-40.7	-26.3	-10.3	- 4.3	- 0.9	+ 0.9	+ 2.3
Never married							
1963	85.1	36.3	12.8	5.8	3.4	3.2	2.6
1971	91.2	53.0	21.6	8.9	4.5	3.7	3.1
% Change	+ 7.2	+46.0	+68.4	+53.4	+32.4	+12.5	+19.2
<u>Sri Lanka</u>							
Currently married							
1963	14.8	57.8	81.0	88.6	89.8	86.1	81.6
1971	10.4	45.9	73.4	85.8	88.9	86.9	83.5
% Change	-29.7	-20.6	- 9.4	- 3.2	- 1.0	+ 0.9	+ 2.3
Never married							
1963	85.0	41.3	17.1	8.3	4.8	4.3	3.9
1971	89.7	53.2	26.6	10.9	5.8	4.7	4.1
% Change	+ 5.2	+28.8	+55.6	+31.3	+28.8	+ 9.3	+ 5.1

During the intercensal period 1963-71, female marriage postponements accounted for 100 percent of the decline in the birth rate while the changing female age structure retarded the decline. Table 7.8 spotlights changes in specific fertility during the intercensal period 1963-71. An appreciable drop of 23.8 percent is noticed in the age group 15-19 while rather moderate declines ranging from 13.5 to 19.1 percent is observed in the next higher segments of the child-bearing span. The declines of fertility in the age groups 15-19, 20-24 and 25-29 may be chiefly explained by reductions in the number of marriages in these age groups.